Alliances versus Diversification

A major area of contention between the US and India in the past was about the kind of partnership each preferred. While the US was developing its alliance system, India was evolving its diversification strategy. In the Cold War, this approach manifested itself in the form of nonalignment; today, people have described it as multialignment.

In the past, when the US and India focused on their quests for alliance or autonomy above all else, it made alignment difficult even when it was necessary. However, when they tolerated, if not accepted, the other country's approach, it facilitated bilateral cooperation. And they did find ways to bridge the gap to work together. But they did not quite figure out the terms of alignment, including what they could expect from each other as aligned—but not allied—countries.

There were various reasons for this. For example, in the US, administrations used to thinking—and organized to think—in terms of allies and adversaries, found it difficult to conceptualize and operationalize what alignment might entail—even when they did want to assist India. In India, a system designed to balance multiple partners did not find it easy to deal with a special one. Another problem was that cooperation in areas like defense trade and technology that would have institutionalized collaboration and created constituencies did not quite take off. The US saw trust-building as preceding technology sharing, while India saw offers of advanced technology as evidence of, or the pathway to, a trusted relationship—something the Soviets better understood. The inability to determine the terms of alignment or calibrate expectations was crucial in unraveling US-India alignment in the past. It is a task that remains challenging in the present day.

Today, those seeking to deal with (or be part of) India's diversification strategy and develop terms of alignment vis-à-vis China need to understand the reasons underlying it. They also need to understand the continued resonance in India of the idea of avoiding dependence—or at least mitigating its risks. And this means that even when India has a need for alignment vis-à-vis China, there will be a competing tendency to grapple with: the desire for autonomy—and particular actions by partners that